

Thinking with Feminisms:

Reflections on Ballet, Binaries, and Beyond

Introduction

Growing up immersed in ballet from age four, a world traditionally allied to femininity, it epitomized the essence of being feminine—delicate, emotional, and deeply intuitive. This paper explores how varied experiences oriented around ballet shaped my understanding of feminist ideas and societal structures. It introduced my journey of thinking about feminism into three stages and offered me a trigger to reflect on feminism and my change in being. Beginning with gendered expectations in ballet, analysis at each stage relates to various feminist perspectives such as gender binary, gender performance, zero-sum issues, intersectionality, and types of feminism. However, throughout the writing process, I recognized that my journey toward embracing feminism was not triggered by a single event but rather a series of introspective challenges, underscoring the circuitous nature of this reflective journey. This tortuous process, in turn, mirrors the development of social-scoped feminism. Lastly, the paper discusses my gradual reconciliation with the feminist identity, or more precisely, my self-positioning within feminist discourse. This progress in adopting the feminist label, as Yoder, Tobias, and Snell (2010) assert, is more crucial than mere awareness of its importance.

The First Offer: Gender Performance and Binaries

I remember, years ago, the feeling of joy mixed with surprise when I learned my ballet peer, Anna, was accepted into the prestigious engineering program at UC Berkeley. This instance is a pivotal moment that taught me to challenge gender roles, especially the femininity assumed by ballet versus the masculinity assumed by logic and rationality in a field like engineering and the entire science field.

Moving from China to the UK for undergraduate studies, I encountered a sociopolitical climate rich in feminist discourse (Guillard 2016), especially on social media, dramatically reshaping my understanding of knowledge and gender relations (Greenhow and Lewin 2016). This environment, coupled with my major in the social sciences, which often deals with gender issues, has enabled me to expand and augment my understanding of gender roles. These exposures have moved me beyond the superficial binary perspective of gender, which sees 'male' and 'female' as mutually exclusive, a notion deeply embedded in societal expectations. I began to question my surprise at Anna's transition from ballet to the technical and logical engineering world and whether it was my internalization of these expectations and constructs, especially regarding the segregation of professions and interests. Since then, I have always considered individual experiences and dilemmas regarding their roots in social and political structures (Hanisch 1969).

It is this engagement with the concept of gender performativity that has unravelled the gender binary. Judith Butler (1990) theorized that gender identities and roles are not innate but are constituted and brought to life through repetitive social enactments, thus portraying gender as a dynamic and diverse practice rather than a binary division. This perspective suggests that attributes like rationality and emotionality are supposed to be detached from their traditional gender associations. 'Rational woman' is, from a feminist point of view, not so much a contradiction in terms but as a normal situation (Prokhovnik 2012). In essence, Anna's move from a domain marked by its femininity to a field deemed masculine is not a transition but a coexistence or reconciliation. This unsettles binary gendered narratives and the deeply but invisibly interconnected normative relations of ballet, sensibility, and femininity, as well as engineering, rationality, and masculinity.

The Second Offer: Challenging Zero-Sum Gender Dynamics

Upon Anna's graduation and subsequent offer from a tech company, our reunion in London brought another revelation for me. As she spoke of leveraging coding in her job, I expressed admiration, confessing that my hesitation in coding stemmed from a self-perceived lack of rationality and mediocrity in mathematics. Anna interjected, "Wait, that's a common misconception. Coding isn't like what you think." At that time, deeply immersed in feminist utopian literature, I had an epiphany that my fundamental misconception lay not in coding but in my narrow imagination of myself, women, and

gender roles and capabilities. This flawed perception was the deep-seated barrier to my grasp of coding. Despite being well-versed in feminist discourse and aware of the growing presence of women in STEM, integrating these inspirations consistently in everyday situations remained a challenge.

At this stage, my reflection centred on how patriarchy limits our imaginative capacity, as underscored in discussions of feminist utopias. The gender binary, I realized, enforced a zero-sum dynamic, where one gender's gain is seen as another's loss (Hare-Mustin 1987). In other words, any gains toward equality made by women "cost" men, creating obstacles to gender equity (Mayer 2017; Ruthig et al. 2016). In contrast, feminist thought illuminates the interrelatedness between reason and emotion, man and woman (Prokhovnik 2012). It challenges the patriarchal apprehension that women's achievements come at men's expense, instead proposing that gender equity yields benefits for society as a whole.

Moreover, the idea that it is the synergy between patriarchy and capitalism that diminishes women's labour force (Hartmann 1976) enlightened me on the undervaluation of "female traits" such as intuition and relationship-building. Seen as mere concessions to male dominance (Gilligan 1982), these traits are mistakenly deemed inferior within the patriarchal zero-sum game. Such erroneous generalizations wrongly suggest women lack the rationality for scientific pursuits or the principles for daily life (Eisenstein 1988), illustrating a more profound issue where "female traits" are

discounted due to a misguided patriarchal bias.

"The personal is political" underscores the connection between individual experiences and broader societal and political contexts (Hanisch 1969). Anna's realization that structural barriers prevent women from exercising autonomy and fulfilling their potential (Yoong 2018) inspired me to reassess the socio-political underpinnings of individual struggles, not to back down but with a transformative perspective and the audacity to resist. Confronted with how patriarchal standards dictate "appropriate" for women (Adisa, Abdulraheem, and Isiaka 2019), I introspected on the gender-based educational segregation entrenched by societal expectations and perpetuated by institutions like schools, family units, and media (Archer et al. 2020; Gupta and Keenan 2022; Institute of Physics 2012, 2020). This novel understanding of the rationale and consequences of the gender binary led to a reexamination of my educational decisions, especially my forsaken pursuit of architectural design, a decision based on the belief that I lacked math skills and logical thinking despite being competent in physics.

Further, the realization that an imaginative, non-binary approach could redefine measures of academic achievement (Gupta and Keenan 2022) echoes that dismantling gender binaries promises a richer collective bounty that defies the zero-sum assumptions inherent in patriarchal gender roles.

The Third Offer: Embracing Intersectionality and Activism

Anna's recent update about our mutual ballet friend, Irene's acceptance to the Massachusetts Institute of Technology, unleashed much thought on my part rather than surprise, sharply contrasting with the amazement I used to feel stemmed from a once narrow perception of gender and a limited view of women's potential.

This shift from "how remarkable she is as a girl who dances ballet with me" to only concentrating on "how outstanding she is." I owe it to the systematic learning of feminist ways of thinking, which resonated with feminist ideas encountered in a school module. The lens of intersectionality has allowed me to focus more sharply on how multiple identities and modes of oppression uniquely affect individual experiences. This notion moves beyond the constrained 'boy discourse' through which differences are often analyzed without considering other dimensions (Lahelma 2014). The mantra "the personal is political" empowers individuals, especially women, to recognize and dismantle structural oppression, while intersectionality provides the tools to challenge monolithic narratives. A comprehensive strategy that, taken together, subverts synergistically entrenched oppression that underpins patriarchal structures. Hanisch, the pioneering voice in coining "the personal is political," further elaborated this in 2006: individual actions embody the broader societal struggle, especially as oppression often occurs in isolated contexts.

On the other hand, the struggle at the individual level is circumscribed; it is collective

activism over the long haul that can contest toxic patriarchy and violent masculinities (Patel 2021). Thus, Individual resistance reflects society's structures and is part of a larger tapestry of societal change. Social structural wrongs cause personal suffering, but feminist activists empower every individual, not just women.

The framework of intersectionality, especially when aligned with postfeminist theories that emphasize the dynamic and diversity of identities, enables a holistic view of how identity and oppression intersect and affect our experience (Crenshaw 1991; Gill 2016) and allows us to "perform a beneficial, therapeutical form of self-socio-analysis and build literacy regarding their own complex social position in the world" (Collins et al. 2021, p. 714).

Our shared background in ballet, a symbol of elite status, simultaneously guided our early gender performativity. Despite these commonalities, our individual experiences and progress in feminist awakening diverge significantly. Anna and Irene diverged from gender perception earlier than I did, successfully navigating STEM fields—a testament to their ability to recognize, challenge, and transcend gender norms. This underscores that their achievements stem not just from aptitude but from a critical consciousness that questioned gender roles—a realization that eluded me when I doubted my mathematical skills, mistakenly attributing it to a lack of ability. Above all, I never honestly expected myself to excel in the sciences.

Considering intersectional differences develops a more thorough cross-cultural analysis (Connell 2009; Davis 2008), such as national variances (Dosekun 2015). In this case, Anna and Irene, raised in the United States, experienced a cultural diversity not available to me in China. Zooming into gender debates, Mohanty (1988), in "Under Western Eyes," identifies differences between the East and West in the micropolitics of context, subjectivity, struggle, and the macropolitics of global economic and political systems. Neoliberal feminism underlines how market mechanisms drive gender equality. This viewpoint helps explain how higher middle-class women capitalized on the more outstanding educational and employment opportunities to break gender occupational segregation, eventually penetrating the upper echelons of power structures within a field that is traditionally male-dominated (Connell 2009; Fraser 2009; Hartmann 1976).

In employing neoliberal feminist perspectives, I strive to recognize Anna's achievements without reducing them solely to individual choice. I remain cognizant of the structural issues and collective actions highlighted by post-feminism and intersectionality (McRobbie, 2009). It is exhausting yet rewarding to reconcile contradictions across multiple perspectives in search of my stance. Also, my privilege within Chinese society, that of being able to receive an education overseas and being able to begin ballet at an early age, requires that I recognize my empowering experiences are not accessible to many marginalized Chinese women. I question whether they can practice or even envisage such empowered ways of being. Critiques

of neoliberalism validate my concerns, as only women with sufficient resources and opportunities in the market can secure tangible advancements (Rottenberg 2018), while those facing more obstacles and unable to compete in the market are left out.

Conclusion

My overall journey of thinking with feminism has been akin to the process of losing fat. Recognizing the need to shed 'mental fat'—unlearn gender stereotypes—we adopt a comprehensive approach through broad feminist education, analogous to overall aerobic efforts essential for full-body fat loss. Despite being familiar with seminal feminist texts such as Woolf's "A Room of One's Own" (1929) and De Beauvoir's "The Second Sex" (1949) during my high school years, integrating these ideas into my daily consciousness was challenging—I still felt surprised at Anna's offer due to her association with ballet. However, through iterative learning and recognizing more profound cognitive limitations, I overcame them with feminist insight. Thinking with feminism is an uncomfortable unravelling process where activists break habitual thinking patterns (Gill 2016), confront contradictions in gender paradigms, and seek to influence society through sharing personal narratives, just as post-feminism participates in the deconstruction of feminism (McRobbie 2004). The enlightening exchanges among women snowball into public discourse, generating broader awareness. Anna guided me by sharing insights highlighting the importance of connecting personal experiences with broader societal and political structures (Lee 2007)—evidence of

Anna's active involvement in the women's rights movement (Swank and Fahs 2017). Having feminist friends like Anna during adolescence, as noted by Smith and Payne (2015), provides exposure to feminist discourse, preventing missed opportunities to disrupt gender bias and enrich feminism's imagination.

These three offers have indeed offered me opportunities to dive into feminism. Understanding the gender binary revealed social structures, while gender performance highlighted core issues, and the rejection of zero-sum thinking deconstructed patriarchal limits on imagination. Embracing intersectionality and the notion that "the personal is political" has shown me how every advance helps to break down complex gender, class, and power dynamics, working towards a more progressive society. Initially, writing reflective essays seemed daunting due to potential biases, but I've come to see my perspective as a source of meaningful contributions to specific discussions. Cultivated by the UK's feminist environment, exposure to feminist literature, and guidance from feminist' friends, my discomfort signifies my active engagement with feminism—questioning and challenging established thoughts and actions.

Most recently, I've made the decision to pursue architectural design during my postgraduate studies, ready to tackle the required advanced mathematics and mechanics. Once hesitant to identify as a feminist, my journey through various narratives, academic engagement, and activism, as well as witnessing societal constraints on personal potential, has cumulatively assembled my feminist standing. What once felt distant is

now integral to my identity—I am now confident in considering myself a feminist.

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